

Tuchel's new England faces Croatia's old guard

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Former England striker Gary Lineker once famously said, "Football is a simple game. Twenty-two men chase a ball for 90 minutes and at the end, the Germans always win." While it was a tongue-in-cheek statement, and England cannot field an XI of German players, the suits at the Football Association have pinned their hopes on the next best thing. After falling short for 60 years on the international stage, England made the controversial decision to appoint a German, Thomas Tuchel, to steer its bid for glory across the Atlantic.

Tuchel's predecessor, Gareth Southgate, struggled to strike a balance with his selections while trying to accommodate England's wealth of attacking midfielders

and No. 10s. Tuchel, however, has been a straight shooter, making the unpopular call to leave out Morgan Gibbs-White, Cole Palmer and Phil Foden, with the latter two omissions aided by their indifferent form. The mercurial Jude Bellingham, the poster boy of the current era, will likely play second fiddle to the in-form Morgan Rogers, a more rounded and functional No. 10.

The attacking options in the squad are geared towards getting the best out of striker Harry Kane. While Kane, 32, is still racking up goals, the FC Bayern Munich forward lacks mobility, a weakness England can offset with the pace of Marcus Rashford, Rogers and Bukayo Saka around him.

England possesses the firepower to go deep into the tournament, but its inexperienced and injury-prone backline will be tested by the short turnaround between



ENGLAND

FIFA Ranking: 4

Appearances: 16

Best finish: Champion
(1966)

Matches: 74

Wins: 32

Draws: 22

Losses: 20

Goals For: 104

Goals Against: 68

Highest scorer in the squad
Harry Kane (**78 goals**)



CROATIA

FIFA Ranking: 11

Appearances: 6

Best finish: Runner-up
(2018)

Matches: 30

Wins: 13

Draws: 8

Losses: 9

Goals For: 43

Goals Against: 338

Highest scorer in the squad
Ivan Perisic (**38 goals**)

